

DAIANA BIRMANOVA

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birmohito.github.io/DesignPortfolio

EDUCATION

Minerva University

Bachelor of Science, Cognition, Brain and Behavior; Minor in Neuroscience
Undergraduate study across seven countries.

San Francisco, CA
Expected 2027

EXPERIENCE

Minerva University Psychology Lab

UX Research Assistant

San Francisco, CA
Sep 2025 - Apr 2026

- Scoped research goals and questions with senior lab researchers, framing the study around how different kinds of background audio affect reading comprehension and task performance.
- Designed a between-subjects experiment in which 45 participants were randomly assigned to answer comprehension questions on a written prompt while hearing either a fast-paced podcast or melancholic instrumental music without lyrics.
- Recruited a volunteer sample of San Francisco residents drawn predominantly from the Minerva student population; coordinated screening, scheduling and session logistics, and built all study materials from prompts and audio stimuli to participant-facing screens and recruitment collateral.
- Piloted every version of the study flow before live data collection; revised instruction wording and pacing reduced measurement error and raised the usable-response rate by 20%.
- Administered sessions to a standardized protocol covering instructions, informed consent and the right to withdraw, then stepped back during the task itself so that observer presence could not disrupt performance under the audio condition.
- Analyzed comprehension and task measures across conditions and qualitatively coded open-ended responses into an inductive codebook; comprehension held roughly equivalent under both audio conditions, and developed two explanatory hypotheses for that null result: neurodivergence within the sample and high academic training.

Joyous Chat (Minerva x Joyous)

Product Designer and Researcher

San Francisco, CA
2023 - 2024; 2025 - Present

- Ran 60+ moderated product testing and usability sessions on an AI-assisted mental health support prototype; coded sessions into themes and translated them into written design requirements for engineering, design and research partners.
- Presented research process, findings and design rationale to industry partners, faculty and a review committee at a research symposium, closing the team phase of the project.
- Relunched the project independently, repositioning it from a therapeutic AI mental health support app to a habit-building journaling product.
- Planned and ran the second research phase end to end: 10 in-depth semi-structured interviews, owning the discussion guide, recruitment and analysis, followed by a 30-response survey to confirm the resulting pain points at scale.
- Coded and thematically analyzed interview data, which contradicted the team's founding assumption: users were not short on motivation, they were stalling at the blank page.
- Evaluated the predictive validity of the Big Five personality instrument the product was built around; quantitative analysis showed it too weak to justify the personalization it promised, and replaced it with declared inputs users select and can correct, covering journaling goals, target areas and prior journaling experience.
- Redesigned onboarding around recurring interview themes (no time, nothing to write about, momentum lost after a few days) so the product asks about the specific barrier each user reports.
- Kept project documentation organized across both phases so data, observations, findings and concept work stayed accessible as the product direction changed.

LEADERSHIP AND COMMUNITY

PScience.intnl

Founder and Research Lead

Kazakhstan
2022 - 2023

- Researched and defined the target audience and its unmet needs, then designed the content system built to meet them.
- Led a 20-person cross-functional team of researchers, writers and designers, growing the platform to 30,000+ users across TikTok and Instagram serving audiences in Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Uzbekistan and wider Central Asia.
- Ran continuous community listening in a moderated Telegram community, coding recurring member pain points into themes that set the content roadmap.
- Selected for the CAYLA Social Innovation Exhibition (11% acceptance rate).